

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Nonprofit and NGO English

Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For nonprofit program managers, NGO staff, grant writers, development officers, monitoring and evaluation teams, field coordinators, volunteer managers, and nonprofit executives.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Mission, Theory of Change, and Program Design

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

02 Grant Proposals and Donor Restrictions

Clarify missing information before responding.

03 Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

04 Field Operations and Partner Coordination

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

05 Safeguarding and Incident Reporting

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

06 Volunteer Management and Training

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

07 Advocacy, Public Messaging, and Neutrality

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

08 Board Reporting and Sustainability

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one case and saying a response. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, conversation, writing, and revision.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Mission, Theory of Change, and Program Design

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

A program reports that 200 people attended workshops and calls this proof of lasting employment improvement. Follow-up outcomes have not been measured.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

mission - An organization's central purpose and intended contribution.

theory of change - An explanation of how activities are expected to contribute to outcomes under stated assumptions.

output - A product or activity delivered by work, such as a report or completed session.

outcome - A change or result achieved, distinguished from the activity delivered.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Improve this sentence: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 01 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
 - B. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
 - C. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?
 - B. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?
 - C. How would you describe the next step in your own words?

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Grant Proposals and Donor Restrictions

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

A team wants to move grant money to another activity. The award's spending restrictions have not been checked.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

restricted funding - Money that may be used only for specified purposes or under stated conditions.

deliverable - A specified item of work to be provided to a customer or project recipient.

grant proposal - An application explaining proposed work, intended outcomes, and funding needs.

mission fit - How well an activity supports an organization's purpose.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Improve this sentence: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 02 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when does the review start?
 - B. Could you confirm when starts the review?
 - C. Could you confirm when the review starts?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Who will present the report at the meeting?
 - B. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?
 - C. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

Participant outcomes improved during a program, but no comparison group or alternative explanation has been examined.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

indicator - A defined measure or observation used to assess a condition or change.

baseline - A defined starting value or agreed reference used to measure change.

attribution - Assigning a result or contribution to a particular source, activity, or cause.

learning agenda - A set of questions an organization plans to investigate to improve its work.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Improve this sentence: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 03 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change definitely caused the delay.
 - B. The change may have contributed to the delay.
 - C. The change must have caused the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. In this pilot, the observed result was ...
 - B. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...
 - C. Across the service, the observed result was ...

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Field Operations and Partner Coordination

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

SITUATION

A field partner changes a planned visit date. The community contact has not yet been told and transport is still booked for the original date.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

implementing partner - An organization responsible for delivering agreed program activities.

field visit - A visit to a project or service location to observe work and meet relevant people.

contingency - A possible future condition or provision for it; in contracts, a condition affecting the transaction.

community trust - Confidence that an organization will act reliably and respectfully toward a community.

3. Notice the language

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

Improve this sentence: Someone should follow up on this.

LESSON 04 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Transfer information and responsibility

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence checks that responsibility has been accepted?
 - A. Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check.
 - B. I mentioned the check in my earlier email.
 - C. The check appears somewhere in the notes.
2. Which response best checks a critical handoff detail?
 - A. I assume all results are final, so we can finish.
 - B. I saw the message, so no clarification is needed.
 - C. So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct?

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Safeguarding and Incident Reporting

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

SITUATION

A volunteer raises a safeguarding concern. The receiving manager must use the organization's established reporting process and handle the information carefully.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

safeguarding - Measures and processes intended to protect people from abuse, exploitation, and other harm.

confidentiality - Protecting information from disclosure to people who are not authorized to receive it.

survivor-centered - An approach that gives priority to a survivor's safety, dignity, preferences, and appropriate support.

incident report - A structured record of an event, available facts, and relevant follow-up information.

3. Notice the language

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Improve this sentence: Please revert soonest with the necessary.

LESSON 05 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask for an actionable next step

4. Check the language

1. What does 'Please send it by Thursday' normally mean?
 - A. Send it on Thursday, but not earlier.
 - B. Keep sending it regularly until Thursday.
 - C. Send it no later than Thursday.
2. Which request gives the recipient enough detail to act?
 - A. Could you confirm that you received my earlier message?
 - B. Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?
 - C. Could you confirm that the review is important?

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Volunteer Management and Training

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

SITUATION

A volunteer is enthusiastic about taking on a task beyond their agreed role and training.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

volunteer role - The agreed tasks, limits, and responsibilities of an unpaid participant.

training - Planned instruction and practice to develop a capability.

supervision - Oversight and support by a person responsible for directing or checking work.

duty of care - A responsibility to exercise appropriate care toward people affected by one's actions.

3. Notice the language

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

In [specific situation], I noticed ...

The effect was ... What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Improve this sentence: You are always careless.

LESSON 06 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Give feedback people can use

4. Check the language

1. Which feedback begins with observable behavior?
 - A. I think the team needs to be more committed to the updates.
 - B. The last two updates omitted the agreed completion date.
 - C. The last two updates seemed less professional than usual.
2. Which follow-up invites useful information before agreeing on support?
 - A. What is making this part of the task difficult?
 - B. Can you promise this will never happen again?
 - C. Would another reminder solve this problem?

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can explain a practical obstacle affecting the work. Share it after your partner asks for your perspective, then agree on one observable change.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Advocacy, Public Messaging, and Neutrality

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

A fundraising draft uses an alarming statistic without its source or date. The campaign team wants to publish immediately.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

advocacy - Communication or action intended to influence decisions on an issue.

campaign - A coordinated set of activities intended to achieve a communication or marketing objective.

dignity - Respect for a person's worth, agency, and privacy.

source - The origin of information, data, or a claim.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Improve this sentence: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 07 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change may have contributed to the delay.
 - B. The change must have caused the delay.
 - C. The change definitely caused the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...
 - B. Across the service, the observed result was ...
 - C. In this pilot, the observed result was ...

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Board Reporting and Sustainability

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

SITUATION

A board considers using reserves or reducing program activity during a funding gap. Some funds are restricted.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

board governance - The structures and practices through which a board directs and oversees an organization.

cash runway - An estimate of how long available cash will last under stated spending assumptions.

reserve - Resources set aside for a purpose; in insurance, an estimate of amounts needed for obligations.

scenario - A description of possible conditions used to explore decisions or practice responses.

3. Notice the language

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Improve this sentence: This option is more better.

LESSON 08 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Explain a fair comparison

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence expresses a clear contrast?
 - A. Option A is faster because option B costs less.
 - B. Option A is faster, so option B costs less.
 - C. Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.
2. A rate increases from 6% to 7%. What is the absolute difference?
 - A. An increase of seven percentage points.
 - B. An increase of one percentage point.
 - C. An increase of one percent relative to the original rate.

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response, not a script to memorize. Your written version needs a subject line, an opening, and appropriate context. Assess it using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Mission, Theory of Change, and Program Design

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

B: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

C: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

Check 2: C - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

B: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

C: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

Model response: Attendance is an output of the program. Lasting employment improvement is an outcome that needs follow-up evidence. I'll distinguish what we delivered from the change we hope to contribute to.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Grant Proposals and Donor Restrictions

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: what this means.

Check 1: C - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

B: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

C: The embedded question uses subject then verb: the review starts.

Check 2: B - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

B: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

C: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

Model response: Does the grant agreement permit this use, or is approval required? Let's confirm the restrictions with the responsible team before presenting the funds as available for the new activity.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: B - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

B: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

C: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

Check 2: A - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

B: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

C: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

Model response: The improvement is observed among participants. We cannot attribute all of it to the program from this evidence alone. I'll describe the result and the limits of the evaluation design.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Field Operations and Partner Coordination

Editing example: Please confirm which team has accepted the follow-up task.

The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Check 1: A - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check.

A: It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.

B: Mentioning a task does not show that anyone accepted it.

C: A written record alone does not identify who will act.

Check 2: C - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct?

A: It changes pending information into a final result.

B: Receiving a message is not the same as confirming its meaning.

C: This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

Model response: The visit date has changed, but communication and transport updates remain open. Please confirm who will contact the community and revise the booking so the handoff includes the practical consequences.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Safeguarding and Incident Reporting

Editing example: Could you send the missing document and confirm when it will be available?

The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Check 1: C - Send it no later than Thursday.

A: By Thursday permits earlier delivery; it is not restricted to that day.

B: This interprets a deadline as a continuing activity, which would use until.

C: 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.

Check 2: B - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

A: This checks receipt, not which version is required for the review.

B: The requested action and information are explicit.

C: This checks importance rather than identifying the needed document version.

Model response: Thank you for raising the concern. I'll help route it through the safeguarding process and explain the next appropriate contact. We should share the information only through the designated channels and avoid investigating informally.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Volunteer Management and Training

Editing example: The last two reports omitted the agreed summary section.

The revision identifies observable work. 'Always' and a personality judgment make the feedback harder to verify or act on.

Check 1: B - The last two updates omitted the agreed completion date.

A: Commitment is an interpretation, not a description of what the updates contained.

B: The recipient can check the specific examples and discuss how to improve them.

C: Less professional is an evaluation; it does not identify a specific observable omission.

Check 2: A - What is making this part of the task difficult?

A: An open question may reveal a barrier the speaker has not considered.

B: A promise does not reveal the obstacle or what support would help.

C: This proposes a solution before finding out what is making the task difficult.

Model response: I appreciate your willingness to help. This task needs preparation and supervision that are not part of your current role. Let's identify an appropriate task today and discuss the training needed for more responsibility.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Advocacy, Public Messaging, and Neutrality

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: A - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

B: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

C: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

Check 2: C - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

B: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

C: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

Model response: We need the source, date, and context before using this statistic. Could we verify what it measures and choose wording that accurately represents the people and situation described?

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Board Reporting and Sustainability

Editing example: This option is better on cost, but slower to deliver.

'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Check 1: C - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.

A: 'Because' claims a causal connection that is not given.

B: 'So' implies one fact causes the other.

C: 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.

Check 2: B - An increase of one percentage point.

A: The new rate is 7%; the difference between the rates is one percentage point.

B: Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

C: A one-percent relative increase on 6% would be 6.06%, not 7%.

Model response: The options have different effects on services and future flexibility. Let's distinguish unrestricted reserves from restricted funds and compare the program implications before the board makes a decision.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Nonprofit and NGO English

Professional audience: nonprofit program managers, NGO staff, grant writers, development officers, monitoring and evaluation teams, field coordinators, volunteer managers, and nonprofit executives

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Mission, Theory of Change, and Program Design

Original fictional case: A program reports that 200 people attended workshops and calls this proof of lasting employment improvement. Follow-up outcomes have not been measured.

Language workshop: Make a complex point clear

Communication goal: Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

Language guidance: Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): In this context, ... means / The difference is that / How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Vocabulary: mission: An organization's central purpose and intended contribution. / theory of change: An explanation of how activities are expected to contribute to outcomes under stated assumptions. / output: A product or activity delivered by work, such as a report or completed session. / outcome: A change or result achieved, distinguished from the activity delivered.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and

an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Attendance is an output of the program. Lasting employment improvement is an outcome that needs follow-up evidence. I'll distinguish what we delivered from the change we hope to contribute to.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Grammar that changes the meaning

1. For a lesson, use its language workshop as the focus. For a dialogue, quote one actual sentence and select one useful grammar feature from it, such as question word order, tense, modality, conditionals or clause linking. Explain in no more than 90 words how this feature helps the speakers do their work. Keep the grammar target narrow.
2. Give two short contrasting sentences using this workplace context. Explain the difference in time, certainty, condition or politeness. Label invented examples and preserve the distinction between possible, planned and confirmed events. Describe context-dependent choices as choices, not universal rules.
3. Give me one editing or sentence-building task using a known case fact. Do not copy the supplied editing example or reveal its answer. Ask me to explain my intended meaning. Stop and wait.
4. After I answer, quote my wording, identify at most two issues, and give a brief explanation and one hint. Ask me to revise before offering a full corrected version. Then accept any accurate, natural alternative that serves the purpose.
5. Continue with two new tasks, one at a time: first guided, then an original response without a sentence frame. End with a two-sentence workplace message using the target feature and a compact self-check. Do not replace this sequence with a worksheet and answer key.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Get feedback on a draft

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TASK: Coach my workplace writing

1. Ask me to paste my own fictional or anonymized draft and identify its reader and purpose. If the reference gives a writing task, mention that task as the default. If it is a dialogue, suggest a brief follow-up message that records its outcome and open questions. Stop and wait. Do not write the message for me first.
2. Once I supply the draft, check it against the reference. If an ambiguity changes the meaning, ask one focused question before rewriting. Do not assume that the draft is correct evidence for a new deadline, approval, diagnosis, cost or commitment.
3. Give feedback in three parts: one effective phrase with a reason; up to three priority improvements, quoting my words; and one short revision task for me. Prioritize incorrect facts or unclear action before minor grammar. For each language correction, explain why it matters to this reader. Label optional stylistic alternatives separately and preserve my level of certainty and intended politeness.
4. Stop and wait for my revision. Then compare the two attempts, identify an improvement and offer one edited version that preserves my voice and purpose. Keep the requested length; if none is specified, use 70-110 words. Explain any meaningful change rather than silently making the message stronger or more certain.
5. Close with one phrase worth reusing and a short transfer task for a different fictional reader. Wait for my attempt before providing another model.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level